In the NEET-UG 2024 case, police say, Pankaj Kumar, a civil engineering graduate from NIT Jamshedpur, slipped into the strongroom at Oasis School in Jharkhand's Hazaribagh—one of the designated exam centres—along with those tasked with securing the question papers on the morning of the exam on May 5. Security footage showed him arriving at 8:02 am and exiting at 9:23 am with digital photos of the paper. By 11:30 am, questions were solved and transmitted to candidates, well before the 2 pm start. Acting on a tip-off, Patna Police raided a safe house—a school where candidates had apparently memorised the answers—and found scraps of burnt paper.

Probe was already underway after Mukhiya's son, Dr Shiv Kumar, a.k.a. Bittu, an MBBS graduate from Patna Medical College, was arrested from Ujjain with four others on April 20 in connection with another leak—one that extended far beyond the test centres. Just two months before NEET-UG, in March 2024, Mukhiya's gang had successfully compromised the Teacher Recruitment Examination (TRE 3.0), meant to fill 87,000 primary and middle school posts in Bihar. This time, they infiltrated the logistics chain. The gang managed to lure Srinivas Chaudhary, a private contractor routinely hired by courier firms to transport sealed question papers. On March 12—just three days before the exam—a vehicle carrying papers to Nawada district made an unscheduled halt at a roadside eatery near Nagarnasa, about 50 km from Patna. There, Mukhiya, his son and their aides pried open the sealed boxes, scanned the contents and swiftly relayed them to their network.

Phase two followed with military precision. Dozens of candidates—each having paid Rs 10-12 lakh—were ferried across the Bihar border in hired SUVs to Hazaribagh, placing them beyond the immediate reach of state authorities. They were lodged in hotels and marriage halls, handed both the questions and model answers, and instructed to memorise them before the test. As many as 270 candidates were caught red-handed with the leaked material. With assistance from Jharkhand Police, the EOU eventually apprehended the entire cohort. The audacity and scale of the operation reignited urgent calls for tighter controls on examination logistics, including stricter vetting of courier partners.

On June 19, the Enforcement Directorate raided 11 locations across five cities—Patna, Nalanda, Ranchi, Lucknow and Kolkata—in connection with the 2023 Bihar constable recruitment scam. The raids uncovered handwritten candidate lists tied to OMR (optical mark recognition) numbers, forged degrees, blank cheques from aspirants and handwritten question sheets matched to specific candidates. The Central Selection Board of Constables had awarded the printing contract to Caltex Multiventures Pvt Ltd—set up in 2021 without a press—which had an undisclosed link to blacklisted Blessing Secured Press Pvt Ltd through director Kaushik Kumar Kar. Even in this case, Mukhiya and his associates had allegedly lifted sealed question paper bundles in transit and leaked them via social media.

HOW COMPUTER-BASED TESTS ARE RIGGED

A SOPHISTICATED SCAM EXPLOITS LOOPHOLES IN DIGITAL INFRASTRUCTURE AND INSIDER COLLUSION TO SUBVERT EVEN THE MOST SECURE EXAMS



Illustration by **RAJ VERMA**

TO PREVENT FUTURE BREACHES, THE EOU HAS SCALED UP ITS SURVEILLANCE MACHINERY AND IS CONTINUOUSLY SHARING LEADS WITH NEIGHBOURING STATES

If Mukhiya built his empire on physical breaches, Ravi Bhushan exploited the digital frontier. Active in Patna since 2017, Bhushan was arrested from Kankarbagh locality on April 7 for orchestrating a proxy server-based fraud that led to the cancellation of an online exam for 4,500 Community Health Officer (CHO) posts in December 2024. With help from the firm contracted to conduct the exam, he allegedly installed remote-access software during mock tests two days before the actual test, effectively opening a backdoor for his 'solver guild' to write the exams in real time (see *How Computer-based Tests are Rigged*). Candidates sat blankly at computers while answers were typed in from afar. Each paid around Rs 5 lakh for the privilege.